

Monteverde Institute

Executive Summary

Client

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Background

The Monteverde Institute (MVI) is a nonprofit educational and research organization in Monteverde, Costa Rica, founded in 1986. With approximately 26 staff members, MVI runs study abroad programs, internships, research initiatives, Spanish language instruction, and conservation projects for an international network of students and partner universities. Programs are primarily funded through academic program revenue. Despite strong offerings, MVI faced challenges with search engine visibility and had no system for turning three years of student evaluation data into public-facing evidence of program impact.

Project Description

Project Opportunity

MVI's website was difficult to find through common searches like "study abroad Costa Rica," limiting recruitment beyond existing university partnerships. At the same time, program evaluation data collected across 90+ Google Sheets sat unused — never aggregated or visualized — leaving MVI to rely on a few qualitative testimonials to communicate impact. Previous website redesigns improved aesthetics but had not addressed discoverability or data-driven storytelling, creating an opportunity to move beyond visual polish toward measurable visibility and impact communication.

Project Vision

The team pursued a two-part approach: improve how people find and understand MVI online, and build internal capacity for sustained impact communication. Website improvements included SEO optimization, FAQ sections, and structural refinements — all within MVI's existing WordPress site. On the data side, the team built a Google Apps Script pipeline that aggregates evaluation data and serves interactive charts on the website, plus an Excel-based internal

dashboard for the Academic Director. Sustainability was a core constraint — every solution uses tools MVI already owns and was documented for non-technical staff.

Project Outcomes

The project improved SEO through Yoast SEO configuration, FAQ sections, and bilingual documentation, giving MVI a repeatable workflow for managing search visibility. Website structure was standardized through Figma wireframes for four pages and an implemented example page, enabling staff to make consistent updates without outside developers. An Excel dashboard consolidated three years of fragmented evaluation data into a single analytical tool the Academic Director can update with a drag-and-drop process. A data pipeline now processes all 90+ evaluation sheets on a nightly schedule, powering 18 embeddable chart types and a curated word cloud on MVI's public website — shifting the organization from manual data collection to active, public-facing program storytelling with no external dependencies.

Project Deliverables

Deliverables include the MVI Academic Dashboard (Excel workbook and documentation), SEO Optimization Documentation (English and Spanish), the Google Apps Script data pipeline with an Operations & Maintenance Guide, and website wireframes with page-level implementation documentation.

Recommendations

The team recommends four actions: standardize the evaluation form so new data flows into the pipeline without manual cleaning; migrate the internal dashboard to a cloud database to eliminate local file dependencies as data grows; establish monthly SEO monitoring using Google Analytics to track visibility improvements; and maintain the delivered documentation over time to keep website updates consistent.

Student Consulting Team

Aidan Plummer served as Quality Assurance Manager. He is a junior majoring in Information Systems with a concentration in data analytics at Carnegie Mellon University, interested in a career in data engineering and analytics.

Alondra Robles served as dashboard lead. She is a senior majoring in Information Systems with a minor in Software Engineering, graduating May 2026. She is interested in transforming complex problems into practical technology solutions.

Anna Shi served as SEO lead. She is a senior majoring in Information Systems and Human-Computer Interaction with a minor in Computer Science, graduating May 2026. She will be working in product management and strategy.

Nihitha Sunil served as website design lead. She is a junior majoring in Information Systems and Business Administration at Carnegie Mellon University, interested in a career in UX design and product strategy.